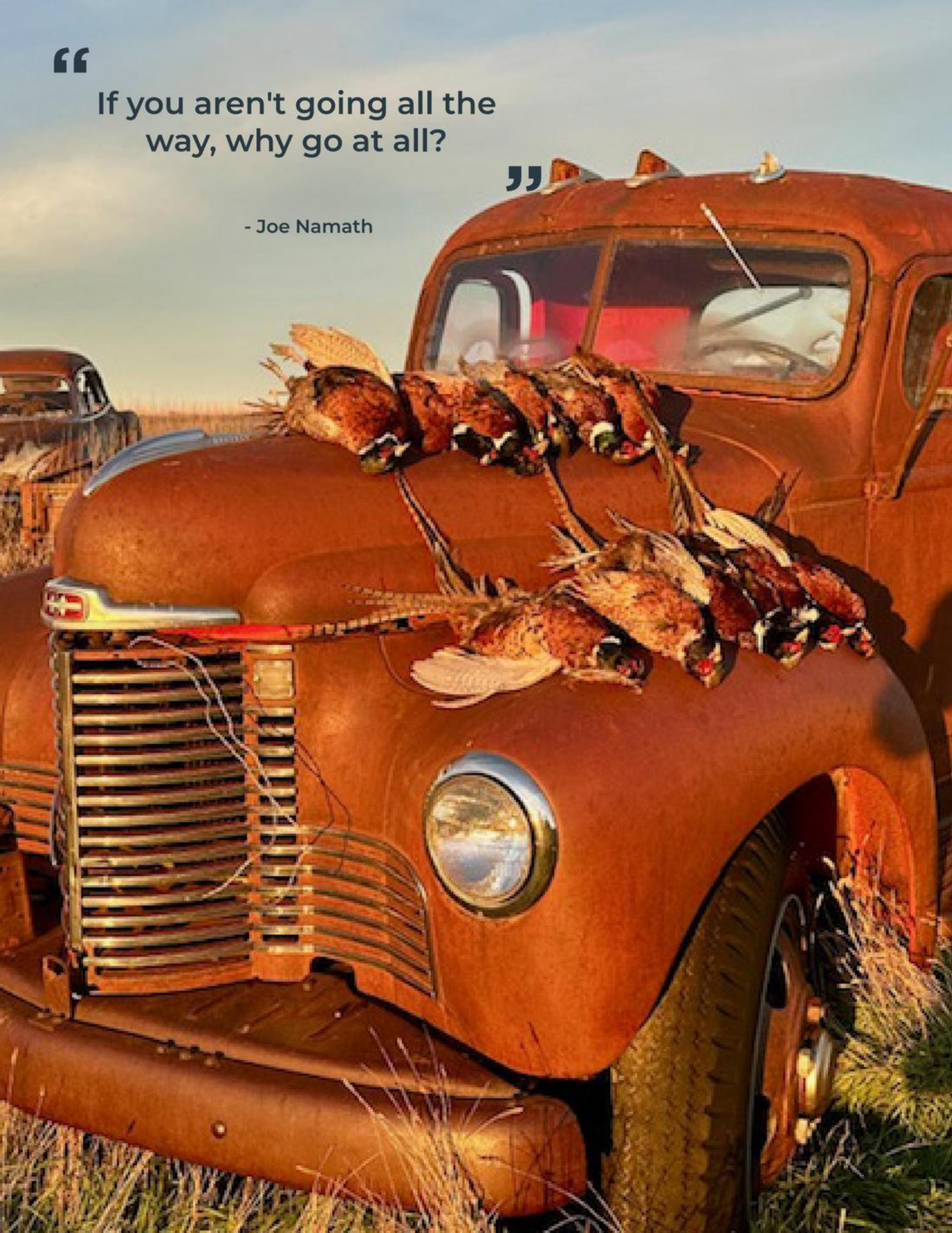


# VISTA UNPLUGGED

## WINTER 2025


“
If you aren't going all the way, why go at all?
”
- Joe Namath

# A Message From Jeff

As we wrap up another eventful year, it's time to reflect on the key developments that shaped 2025 in the realms financial markets, and family first of course.

2025 was quite the year for the Speicher household. As we encourage our clients to do, we soaked it all in as the days flew by, knowing we only get one shot at this life.

Tyrsa graduated from Kansas State, then moved to Dallas for an exciting opportunity with Prospera Financial Services in their Ignite Program. As much as we'd love to have her closer, we're incredibly proud of the young woman she's becoming. I was fortunate to be there for her baptism—a meaningful step she felt called to take as she grows spiritually.

Wesley wrapped up the summer with another BMX state championship in the cruiser class and a second-place finish on his class bike. Fortunately, my parents were there to share the experience. Despite missing much of summer football practice, we were thrilled to see our sophomore start on the DHS JV team as a defensive linebacker.




Thess and I traveled to the Broadmoor for the Prospera Director's Circle in the spring, deepening friendships along the way. In the summer, we caught the Red Clay Strays at Red Rocks, and we made time for some laughs with a quick trip to Albuquerque to see Bert Kreischer.

In the markets, 2025 proved resilient and rewarding for investors. The S&P 500 delivered strong gains, rising 14.8% year-to-date through the third quarter, fueled by AI-driven technology stocks and robust consumer spending. U.S. large-cap stocks climbed 14.83%, small caps gained 10.39%, and international developed markets surged 25.72%, reflecting a broader global recovery despite tariff uncertainties and a 43-day federal government shutdown earlier in the year.

Looking ahead to 2026, I'm optimistic about the opportunities on the horizon. With a foundation of policy reforms and market strength, we have the tools to navigate challenges and build toward greater prosperity. Here's to a bright new year filled with innovation, growth, and success for all.

With Gratitude,

**Jeff Speicher, AIF®**
**Founder - Managing Director**

# VISTA UNPLUGGED NEWS

## What's Inside:


A Bucket List Adventure

Winter Reading Idea

Why Munis, Why with Prospera, & Why Now

A Memorable Trip to Dallas

15 Essential Money Lessons

The $27 Trillion Retirement Tax Trap

Albert Einstein 8th wonder of the world

Traditional New Year's Meals Around the World

Recipe Corner

Vista UnPlugged Closing



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## A BUCKET LIST ADVENTURE

# Pheasant Hunting in South Dakota – Reconnecting and Building Bonds

In the crisp autumn air of South Dakota's vast prairies, where golden fields stretch endlessly under wide-open skies, lies an experience that transcends the thrill of the hunt. For many, a pheasant hunt in this heartland state isn't just about bagging birds—it's a bucket list journey that weaves together adventure, camaraderie, and the timeless art of nurturing relationships. Whether gathering with long-time friends and family or opening doors to new connections, this pursuit offers a unique backdrop for meaningful interactions that strengthen personal and professional ties.

**The Allure of South Dakota Pheasant Hunting**

South Dakota is renowned as the "Pheasant Capital of the World," drawing hunters nationwide each fall. With over a million ring-necked pheasants flushed annually from cornfields and grasslands, the state boasts abundant, accessible hunting grounds. Imagine starting your day at dawn, shotgun in hand, as the sun rises over rolling hills dotted with shelterbelts—rows of trees providing wildlife cover. It's not just the adrenaline; it's immersion in nature's rhythm, where every step through the brush highlights life's simple joys.

For bucket-listers, this hunt is more than sport—it's an escape from the daily grind, unplugging from distractions to embrace tradition. Outfitters provide guided trips with expert dogs, cozy lodges, and meals from the harvest, blending excitement and relaxation for novices and pros alike.

**Reconnecting with Long-Time Friends and Family**

In our fast-paced world of emails and Zoom, nothing beats face-to-face time demanding presence and teamwork. Last October, I gathered with my son and a few college friends I hadn't seen in years, and my two brothers for a pheasant hunt in South Dakota. We all knew we should spend more time together, but life—work, families, excuses—gets in the way.

We booked a year ahead on a mutual friend's recommendation. Good call: waiting a month out would've yielded 20 reasons to bail. Meeting at an Airbnb in Pierre, we stayed up late catching up, laughing over old stories. Luckily, regulations ban hunting before 10 AM (birds feed early), so we slept it off.
Our guides led with the dogs and strategized positions, while the rest of us traded jabs over shots missed. Shared triumphs and misses felt like therapy, reinforcing why these ties endure.

**Making New Friends Amid the Hunt**

New friendships bloom over lunch in the field, crossing a fence, and dinners after a long day. We got to know our guides, all of whom have very interesting backgrounds, turning them from strangers to new friends through shared passion. None of them guide for the money; instead, they've figured out how to subsidize their passions while meeting others who love the outdoors.

**Nourishing Relationships: The Lasting Impact**

At its core, this bucket list hunt is relationship stewardship. It demands intention: physical activity boosts endorphins and downtime fosters connection. We all returned with tales and renewed appreciation for each other and the time we share "unplugged."

Balancing work and life, such trips highlight true wealth in experiences and connections. Plan yours: invite long-time contacts to

*continued on pg. 6*

make memories, welcome newcomers. Bonds formed out in  fields last well beyond the season.

Whether flushing pheasants or soaking in scenery, it's a reminder: life's richest moments stem from deep connections. If South Dakota calls, grab your gear, gather your circle, and let the hunt begin. The relationships nurtured WILL be your greatest trophy.

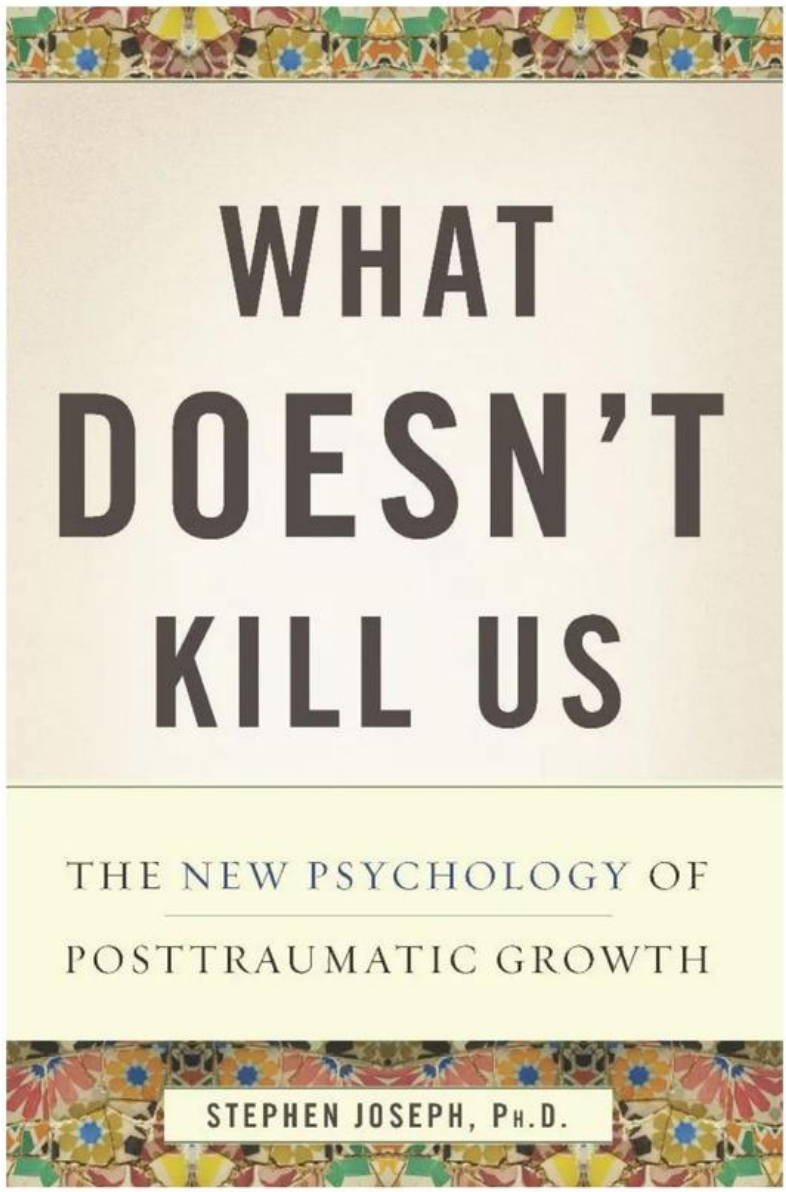


*Top row: J, Wes, and Jeff*
*Bottom row: Jon, Josh*

# Winter Reading Idea

### Overview

As humble warriors, we all accumulate scars over the years. Those who know my family well understand we've been through the wringer—with complicated pregnancies, premature deaths, and unwanted legal battles. Your scars are uniquely yours, but we all carry them. Especially now, post-global shutdown, it's hard to find anyone untouched by major challenges. Our kids certainly haven't been spared. I've always heard "what doesn't kill us makes us stronger," but this book explains why—and how to turn those scars into armor.




In "What Doesn't Kill Us: The New Psychology of Posttraumatic Growth," psychologist Stephen Joseph flips the script on trauma. Published in 2011, it explores how adversity doesn't just scar us—it can spark profound personal growth. Drawing on decades of research, Joseph introduces posttraumatic growth (PTG), where survivors emerge stronger, wiser, and more resilient.

Joseph contends that while posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD) dominates discussions, many experience positive changes after crises like illness, loss, or accidents. Through real-life stories—cancer survivors discovering deeper purpose, accident victims building stronger bonds—he outlines PTG's five domains: **personal strength, closer relationships, new possibilities, appreciation for life, and spiritual change.** The title echoes Nietzsche's famous line, underscoring that what doesn't destroy us can rebuild us better.

What distinguishes this book is its hopeful yet honest tone, never minimizing pain. Joseph weaves scientific studies with practical guidance, offering six steps for navigating trauma: taking stock, harnessing support, embracing change, expressing emotions, identifying growth, and building resilience. It's approachable for everyday readers, sidestepping jargon while rooting ideas in positive psychology.

For readers drawn to self-improvement or psychology—like me and, I suspect, many of you—this is a refreshing, empowering read. It reminds us growth often lurks in our darkest moments, without preaching. Highly recommended: grab it to turn your "what ifs" into "what nows."

# Why Munis, Why with Prospera, & Why Now

By Chris Bravender
Fixed Income Manager
PROSPERA FINANCIAL SERVICES

Twenty-eight years ago, as a rookie financial advisor at PaineWebber, I honed my skills by cold-calling prospects and pitching the benefits of tax-free municipal bonds. It was a golden era for munis: Our dedicated Dallas trading desk offered direct market access and customized inventory tailored to clients' needs—and they were straightforward to explain. "Smile and dial," my mentor advised. "Your second-favorite answer is no." I'm relieved those grueling days are behind me; it makes me feel ancient explaining to young advisors that yes, dialing 400–500 people daily for five years was how we built careers in the "black-and-white TV" era.



Fast forward to today, and the landscape has shifted dramatically. Many municipal bond trading desks have shuttered, with firms consolidating into a "one-size-fits-all" institutional model. This evolution has left retail advisors and their clients at a disadvantage—often limited to bonds that institutions have already cherry-picked or inflated with multiple markups before they reach us. Prior to joining Prospera, these market dynamics severely restricted my ability to deliver genuine value in municipal bonds for my clients.

That changed a few years ago when Prospera acquired Dorsey and Company out of New Orleans, LA. Last October at our Connect Conference, I had the chance to connect with Chris Bravender, our Fixed Income Manager. Chris and his team have over 70 years of expertise in the municipal bond arena, Chris has built a stellar reputation for trading and crafting customized tax-free portfolios for both individual investors and institutions.

*"Unlike corporates, munis benefit from the power to tax and strong legal protections for bondholders."*

## The Harsh Reality of Municipal Bonds: Why Expertise Matters

Municipal bonds aren't for everyone. Like any investment, it's wise to consult an expert to determine if individual bonds fit your needs. But here's the truth: Not all financial advisors deeply understand fixed-income markets or the vital role individual bonds play in portfolios. Many lacking this expertise default to one-size-fits-all bond funds or generic separately managed accounts (SMAs) run by outsiders who don't know you or your goals.

Advisors without the know-how to source individual bonds often outsource to packaged products—but this comes with unintended consequences when sponsors aren't aligned with your interests.

At Prospera, we master the complexities of tax-free and taxable income. Our in-house team boasts over 70 years of experience helping advisors, institutions, and retail clients build customized bond portfolios tailored to unique income needs. We curate individual bonds with confidence, letting you see your own coupons and maturity dates—a key feature bond funds can't provide. While SMAs might offer this, they typically limit you to a narrow menu of generic strategies, often requiring millions for any real attention from managers.

We start with a conversation: Understanding your income expectations and tax situation guides us toward tax-exempt bonds, taxable bonds, or a hybrid. From there, we educate on generating consistent, reliable cash flow from traditional tax-exempt munis or taxable munis—an underappreciated option for those seeking municipal safety in retirement accounts or low-tax scenarios.

Munis appeal due to their ultra-low default rates. Investors prioritize safety but often chase yield in riskier assets. Our market expertise pairs capital preservation with competitive income, rivaling or exceeding lower-quality bonds.

Unlike corporates, munis benefit from the power to tax and strong legal protections for bondholders. Issuers must dedicate irrevocable revenue streams—like property taxes, sales taxes, or essential services—to debt service before other expenses. This explains why A-rated munis default far less than AAA corporates.

Safety, cash flow, and call protection make munis timeless, but today's market is especially attractive. For top taxpayers, 15-30 year tax-exempt munis offer tax-equivalent yields over 6% to call and 7% to maturity. Taxable munis yield 75-100 basis points above comparable Treasuries.

Munis aren't just for the elite. Those in the 24% federal bracket can achieve 5.25%-6% tax-equivalent yields, potentially higher with in-state bonds. Good luck finding that today at your bank. They're ideal for investors adding duration for reliable income and may be a good alternative for those of you keeping large deposits at the bank either personally or for your business. Speicher Private Wealth can get you a seat at our table—starting at $500,000—to explore tailored municipal portfolios that deliver income you can count on. Give me a call at (970) 828-7000.



*Prospera advisors at the CONNECT conference.*

# A Memorable Trip to Dallas: Professional Connections, Community Service, and Family Joy

Spending time at our home office in Dallas was more than just a business trip—it was a perfect blend of professional development, giving back to the community, and creating cherished family memories. Prospera's "CONNECT" conference brought together colleagues for a mix of training sessions and networking opportunities. But the experience extended far beyond the office, culminating in a heartfelt weekend with my daughter in and around Dallas and Fort Worth.

The CONNECT conference kicked off with an energizing atmosphere at our Dallas headquarters. Designed to foster collaboration and skill-building, the program included interactive workshops on the latest trends in wealth management, from investment strategies to client relationship building. It was inspiring to connect with like-minded professionals in our boutique firm, sharing insights and building relationships that will undoubtedly strengthen our team and benefit our clients. These sessions weren't just about business; they emphasized the importance of work-life balance and community involvement, setting the tone for the rest of the day.

One of the most rewarding parts of the event was our group activity: assembling care packets for A Soldier's Hands, a non-profit organization dedicated to supporting deployed troops overseas. A Soldier's Hands focuses on distributing personalized care packages to soldiers and sailors, ensuring no one in a unit is left out. These packets often include essentials like skin care products to help with the harsh conditions they face. Coming together with colleagues to pack these items was a humbling reminder of the sacrifices made by our service members. It added a layer of purpose to the event, turning our networking into a meaningful act of service.

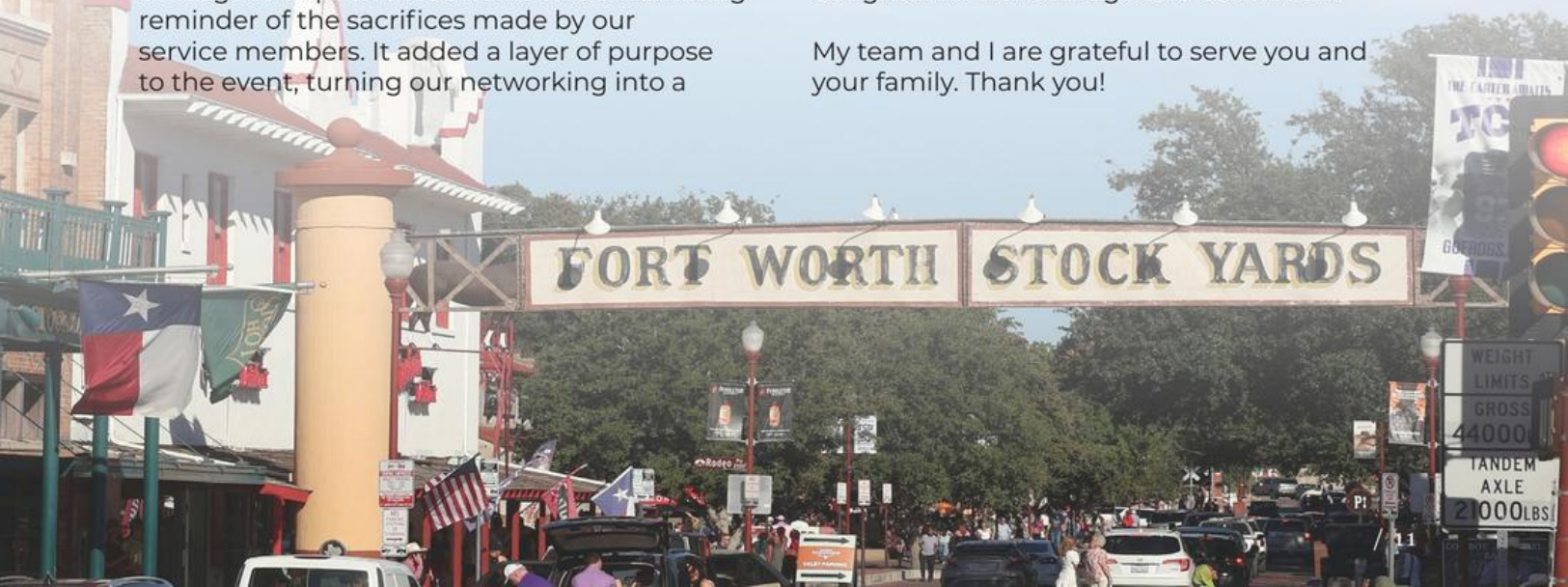
After the event wrapped up, I extended my stay to spend the weekend with my daughter in Fort Worth, just a short drive from Dallas. We dove into the city's rich Western heritage, starting with the iconic Fort Worth Stockyards. The highlight was watching the twice-daily cattle drive, where authentic Texas longhorns are herded down Exchange Avenue by cowboys on horseback—a living piece of history that captures the spirit of the Old West.

**Cowboys and Cattle Drives at the Fort Worth Stockyards**
We wandered the bustling streets, soaking in the sights, sounds, and smells of this vibrant district. From browsing shops filled with cowboy boots and hats to enjoying some classic Texas barbecue, it was a fun, immersive way to bond and explore.

The weekend reached an emotional peak when my daughter made the personal decision to get baptized. Witnessing her take this step of faith was profoundly moving—a moment of growth and commitment that filled me with immense pride. It's these unexpected, heartfelt experiences that make family time so special, turning a simple weekend getaway into something unforgettable.

Reflecting on the trip, from the professional insights gained at Connect to the joy of family adventures in Fort Worth, it was a reminder of how work, service, and personal life can intersect in beautiful ways. I'm grateful for the opportunity and especially proud of my daughter for her courage and conviction.

My team and I are grateful to serve you and your family. Thank you!



# 15 Essential Money Lessons to Teach Your Kids and Grandkids Early

Financial literacy isn't taught in schools—it's up to you as a parent or grandparent to fill that gap. In a world where money decisions can shape futures, starting these conversations early is vital. By sharing these 15 lessons, you're not just passing on knowledge; you're arming the next generation with tools for independence, resilience, and prosperity. Here's how to guide them with clarity and purpose.

1. **Money Is a Tool, Not the Goal**
   Money isn't the prize—it's a tool to solve problems and create opportunities. Teach kids that it's more than buying toys; it can fund education, health, or help others. As Zig Ziglar said, "You can have everything in life you want if you just help enough other people get what they want." Foster gratitude and service, and show them to value the impact money can make—like launching a business or supporting a cause—over the money itself.

2. **Failure Is Tuition in the School of Success**
   Redefine failure as a stepping stone. Encourage kids to see it as a lesson paid for with experience, not something to fear. Share your own stories—a failed venture or a career misstep—and what you learned. Urge them to try, fail, learn, and keep going. Falling down isn't the problem; staying down is. This mindset builds resilience for life's challenges.

3. **Start Investing Yesterday**
   Time is the secret weapon of wealth. Explain compound interest—how money grows exponentially over time. Teach that staying invested consistently beats trying to time the market. Introduce the Rule of 72: divide 72 by the interest rate to estimate when an investment doubles. Stress that small, regular investments, started early, create massive results.

4. **Work to Learn, Not to Earn**
   Shift their focus from paychecks to growth. Every job, even flipping burgers, is a classroom for skills like communication or problem-solving. These "tools" outlast temporary wages. Encourage them to seek roles that teach, not just pay. Skills are forever; paychecks are fleeting.

5. **Networking Outweighs Grades**
   Grades open doors, but networks build empires. Every interaction—with peers, teachers, or professionals—is a chance to learn or connect. Teach kids to offer value first, like helping with a project or sharing ideas. Over time, who they know and how they nurture relationships will matter more than their GPA.



6. **Make Every Dollar Bring a Friend Back**
   Treat money like a worker with a job. If a dollar leaves your pocket and doesn't return with "friends" (value or returns), it's not working hard enough. Before spending, ask: Will this dollar grow through investments or smart purchases, or is it gone for good? This mindset makes every financial decision intentional.

7. **Think Ownership, Not Just Income**
   Salaries are a start, but ownership is the goal. Introduce assets like real estate, stocks, or mutual funds that build wealth over time. Instead of working for a company, encourage owning a piece of it through shares. An ownership mindset turns effort into lasting financial security.

8. **Master Emotions to Master Money**
   Greed and fear are money's worst enemies, driving impulsive choices like panic-selling or overspending. Teach kids to base financial decisions on logic, not emotion. Analyze investments with data, not hype, and spend with purpose. Emotional discipline is key to avoiding wealth-draining traps.

9. **Time Is More Valuable Than Money**
   Money is renewable; time is not. Help kids calculate their hourly value (earnings divided by hours worked) to weigh if tasks are worth their time. Emphasize investing time in relationships, health, and growth, not just work. Time well-spent creates a richer life than money alone.

10. **Good Debt vs. Bad Debt**
    Debt isn't all bad, but it's not all good either. Bad debt, like credit card balances for depreciating items, is a leaky bucket. Good debt, like a loan for a rental property that generates income, is a strategic tool. Teach them to borrow only for assets that grow wealth and pay for themselves.

11. **Delayed Gratification Is a Superpower**
    In an instant-gratification world, patience is a game-changer. Share the mantra: Live today like no one else would, so tomorrow you can live like no one else could. Show how skipping trendy purchases to invest leads to bigger rewards. This principle applies to money, careers, and relationships.

12. **Buy Quality, Cry Once**
    Cheap purchases often cost more in repairs or replacements—buy quality and pay once. This applies to things and people: choose friends, partners, or business allies who add lasting value. Frame every purchase as an investment in quality, not just an expense.

13. **Give to Grow**
    Generosity fuels growth. Giving time, money, or knowledge builds connections and opens doors. Teach kids that true wealth includes contributing to something bigger than themselves. The returns—whether in relationships or opportunities—often come back tenfold.

14. **Build Multiple Income Streams**
    One income source is a risk; diversify to thrive. Encourage side hustles, from freelancing to small ventures, alongside a main job. This builds resilience, sparks creativity, and ensures they're never dependent on a single paycheck.

15. **Make Money Work Harder Than You**
    Don't slave for money—make it work for you. Build systems like automated investments or passive income streams from assets like stocks or properties. These generate returns with minimal effort, paving the way to true financial freedom.

By teaching these lessons early, you're giving your kids and grandkids a head start toward a secure, fulfilling future. Lead by example, start with one lesson, and watch them grow into financially savvy adults. Which lesson will you share first?



# The $27 Trillion Retirement Tax Trap: How

In today's financial landscape, Americans have amassed an astonishing $27.3 trillion in individual retirement accounts (IRAs) and 401(k) plans—much of it in tax-deferred accounts poised for significant taxation upon withdrawal. This vast sum, accumulated through years of diligent saving and investment, forms a cornerstone of your retirement security. Yet, without strategic planning, a substantial portion could be eroded by unnecessary taxes. By understanding this risk and considering options like Roth IRA conversions, you can better protect your wealth for yourself and your heirs, particularly with potential tax changes on the horizon.

**The Hidden Risks in Tax-Deferred Accounts**

Tax-deferred retirement vehicles, such as traditional IRAs and 401(k)s, offer compelling upfront advantages: contributions reduce your taxable income, and earnings grow tax-free until withdrawal. However, this deferral has a downside—distributions in retirement are taxed as ordinary income, potentially at elevated rates if your tax bracket increases or if federal tax policies shift. Moreover, required minimum distributions (RMDs) begin at age 73, compelling you to withdraw funds and incur taxes, even if you don't need the money immediately.

The magnitude is eye-opening. As of the second quarter of 2025, IRAs hold $18 trillion, while 401(k) plans account for $9.3 trillion. The majority of these assets are in traditional, tax-deferred structures, ensuring the IRS will eventually take its cut. If unaddressed, this could result in hefty tax liabilities, especially when passing assets to heirs in higher brackets. The SECURE Act's 10-year rule for non-spouse beneficiaries exacerbates this, mandating faster withdrawals and potentially higher taxes, diminishing the legacy you've worked to create.

**How Roth Conversions Can Help You**

A Roth IRA conversion serves as a simple yet potent counterstrategy. By moving funds from a traditional IRA or 401(k) to a Roth IRA, you pay taxes on the converted amount upfront. In return, future growth and qualified withdrawals (after age 59½ and a five-year holding period) are entirely tax-free. Additionally, Roth IRAs are exempt from RMDs during your lifetime, affording greater control over your financial and estate planning.

**Key benefits include:**

- **Tax-Free Growth and Access:** Secure taxes at current rates, allowing your investments to compound without future tax burdens.
- **Advantages for Heirs:** Beneficiaries receive assets tax-free, sidestepping the income tax challenges of traditional accounts—especially beneficial under the 10-year distribution rule.
- **Shield Against Tax Increases:** The Tax Cuts and Jobs Act (TCJA) provisions are set to expire at the end of 2025, potentially reverting tax rates to pre-2018 levels in 2026 and raising the top bracket from 37% to 39.6%. Converting now could lock in lower rates before any hikes take effect.



# Roth Conversions Can Protect Your Wealth

Conversions aren't one-size-fits-all; they should align with your personal circumstances. Factors like your current income, projected future brackets, and market conditions matter—for instance, converting during a market downturn minimizes the tax on lower asset values. Phasing conversions over several years can also help stay within favorable tax brackets.

**Why Act Now?**
The window for action is narrowing. With the TCJA's sunset approaching, higher rates could arrive in 2026 unless Congress intervenes, making 2025 a strategic time to convert. Retirement assets are at record levels, magnifying the benefits of proactive steps. As tax policy debates continue in Washington, delaying could mean forfeiting today's opportunities.

Consider this example: If you're in the 24% bracket and convert $100,000 today, you could sidestep a 28% or higher rate later, potentially saving thousands. Pairing this with strategies like tax-loss harvesting can amplify efficiency.

Last month, one of our clients, a 62-year-old retiree from a major construction firm, benefited from a Roth conversion analysis. We presented a plan that projects over $1 million in reduced future federal taxes, while growing his total assets to more than $2 million by the end of his life and keeping him and his wife under the income level where Medicare would penalize them. That's what we call "real money."

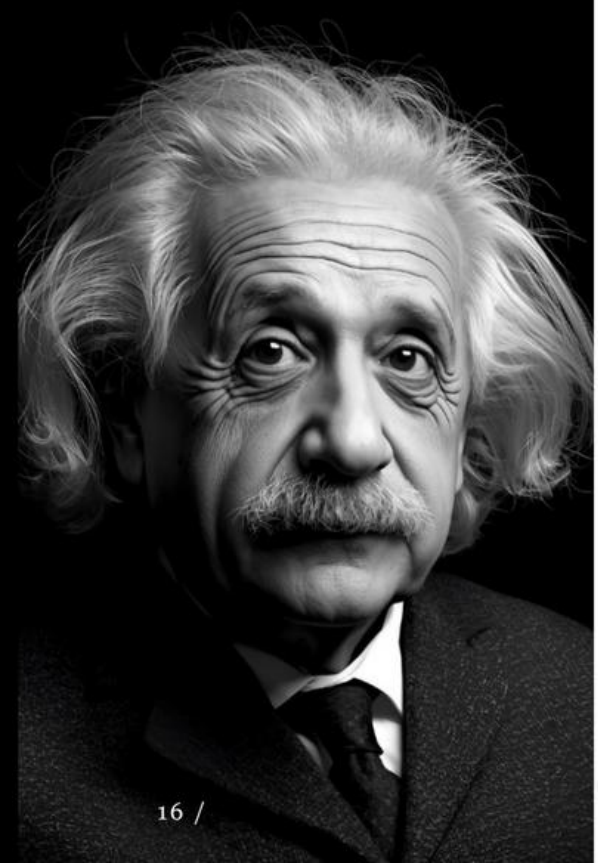
**Taking the Next Step**
This $27 trillion in tax-deferred savings isn't merely a number—it's the foundation of your future. Exploring a Roth conversion can help reduce avoidable taxes, increase flexibility, and bolster your wealth transfer goals. If this strikes a chord, let's talk. Our new planning tool, Right Capital, which we are rolling out currently allows us to model what that looks like for you.

*"AS OF THE SECOND QUARTER OF 2025, IRAS HOLD $18 TRILLION, WHILE 401(K) PLANS ACCOUNT FOR $9.3 TRILLION."*

SPEICHER | PRIVATE WEALTH

# Albert Einstein 8th wonder of the world

*"Compound interest is the eighth wonder of the world. He who understands it, earns it... he who doesn't... pays it."*



Albert Einstein is widely, though perhaps apocryphally, quoted as saying, "Compound interest is the eighth wonder of the world. He who understands it, earns it; he who doesn't, pays it." The concept of "power of compounding" refers to how reinvested interest generates further interest, leading to exponential growth over time, a principle best explained by a snowball effect where a small, early investment grows significantly with time and continued contributions.

## What is compounding?

Compounding occurs when the interest earned on an investment is reinvested, so that future interest is calculated on both the initial principal and the previously accumulated interest.

It contrasts with simple interest, where interest is only calculated on the original principal amount.

## Why is it so powerful?

- **Exponential Growth**
  Compounding creates an accelerating growth curve, making a substantial difference over longer periods.
- **"Snowball" Effect**
  A small amount of money grows at an increasing rate, similar to a snowball rolling down a hill and gathering more snow.
- **Long-Term Impact**
  The longer money is invested, the greater the impact of compounding.

## Key Takeaways

- **Start Early**
  Beginning to save and invest early, even with small amounts, allows more time for compounding to work its magic.
- **Consistency**
  Regularly adding to your investments and reinvesting earnings helps accelerate the snowball effect.
- **Time is Crucial**
  The "long hill" for the snowball refers to having many years for your investments to grow, as seen in Warren Buffett's career.
- **Manage Costs**
  Keep fees and taxes to a minimum to maximize the



# Traditional New Year's Meals Around the World

As the clock strikes midnight, cultures worldwide celebrate with symbolic foods representing prosperity, health, and good fortune. These traditions blend history, superstition, and regional flavors to usher in the new year. Here's a concise look at some global customs, starting with the Americas.

**Americas: Hearty Dishes for Hope and History**
In the Southern United States, Hoppin' John—a mix of black-eyed peas, rice, pork, and collard greens—is a New Year's Day staple. Peas symbolize coins for wealth, greens represent money, and the dish draws from African roots for promises of prosperity.

Mexico rings in the year with tamales, labor-intensive corn dough parcels filled with meats or veggies, symbolizing family unity and celebration.

Haiti commemorates January 1st (also Independence Day) with soup joumou, a squash stew with beef and veggies, once forbidden to enslaved people, now embodying freedom.

**Europe: Sweets, Savories, and Luck**
Spain's "Las Doce Uvas de la Suerte" involves eating 12 grapes at midnight for monthly good luck, a tradition from grape farmers.

The Netherlands enjoys oliebollen, fried dough balls with raisins, tied to ancient myths for protection and now a festive treat.

Italy serves lentils with sausage post-midnight, their shape evoking coins for wealth.

Greece bakes vasilopita cake with a hidden coin for luck, honoring Saint Basil.

Scandinavia and Poland favor pickled herring, its silver scales symbolizing abundance.

**Asia and Beyond: Noodles and Symbolic Foods**
Japan's toshikoshi soba noodles, slurped unbroken at midnight, represent longevity and cutting old ties.

South Korea's tteokguk rice cake soup grants an extra year of age and fortune during Lunar New Year.

China's longevity noodles, uncut strands, symbolize a long life.

Turkey smashes pomegranates for scattered seeds predicting fortune.

These meals connect us to our aspirations—may yours bring luck in 2026!

# RECIPE CORNER

## Good Luck Pork and Sauerkraut

As a boy growing up in Lancaster County PA we always started the year with this Pennsylvania Dutch classic—pork for progress and sauerkraut for prosperity. A hearty, easy meal for New Year's or any day.

**Ingredients (Serves 6-8)**

- 2 lbs sauerkraut (with brine, *I make my own, so let me know if you'd like that recipe.*)
- 2 lbs pork shoulder
- 1 lb kielbasa
- 2 Tbsp brown sugar
- 1 tsp caraway seeds
- Olive oil
- Water (as needed)

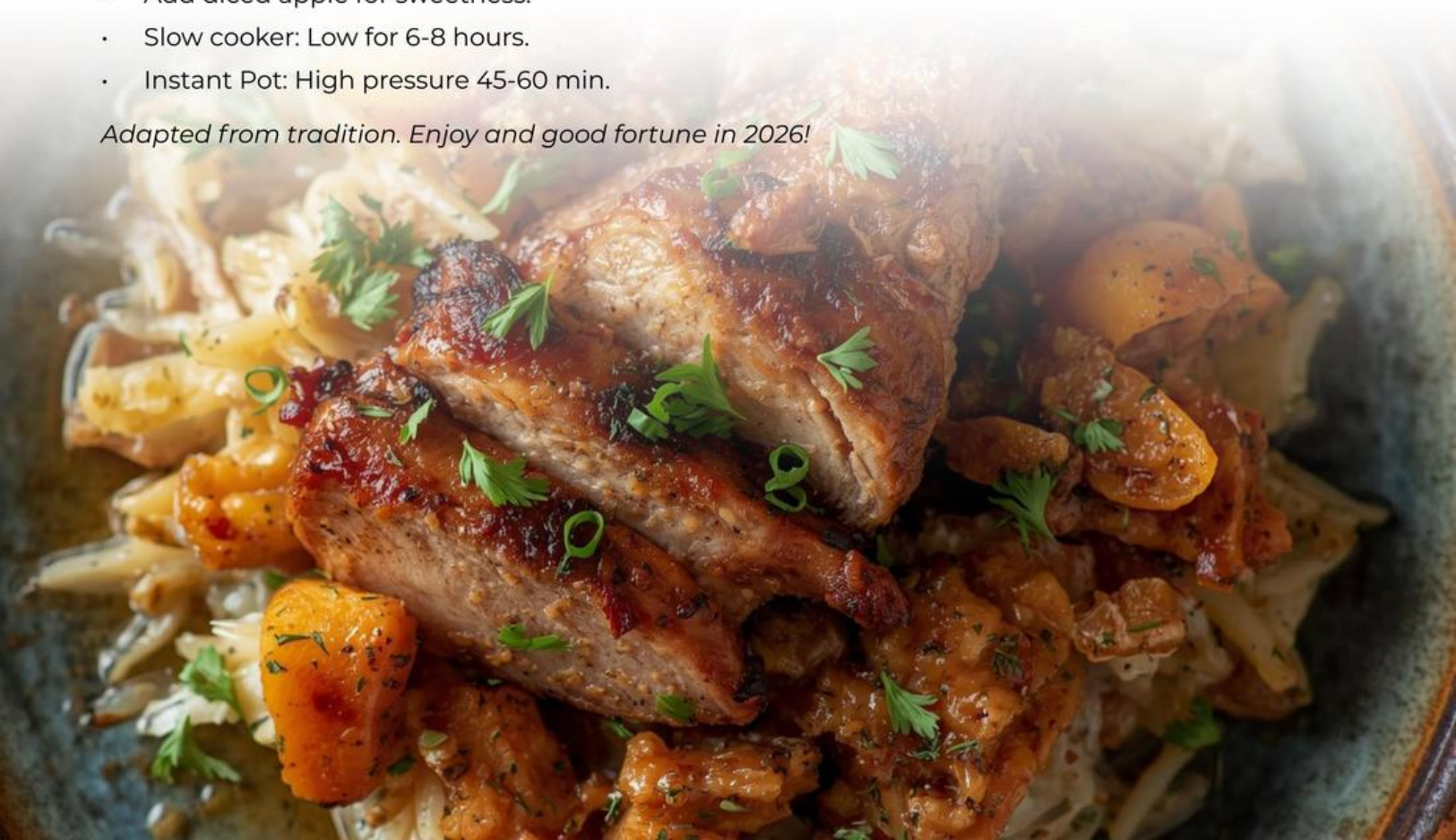
**Instructions**

1. Heat oil in a Dutch oven; brown pork on all sides.
2. Add sauerkraut with brine, sliced kielbasa, brown sugar, and caraway seeds.
3. Add water to cover pork; boil, then simmer covered for 3-4 hours until pork shreds.
4. Serve with mashed potatoes.

**Quick Tips**

- Add diced apple for sweetness.
- Slow cooker: Low for 6-8 hours.
- Instant Pot: High pressure 45-60 min.

*Adapted from tradition. Enjoy and good fortune in 2026!*



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